Non-focal prominence: What if it is phonological?

Shigeto Kawahara
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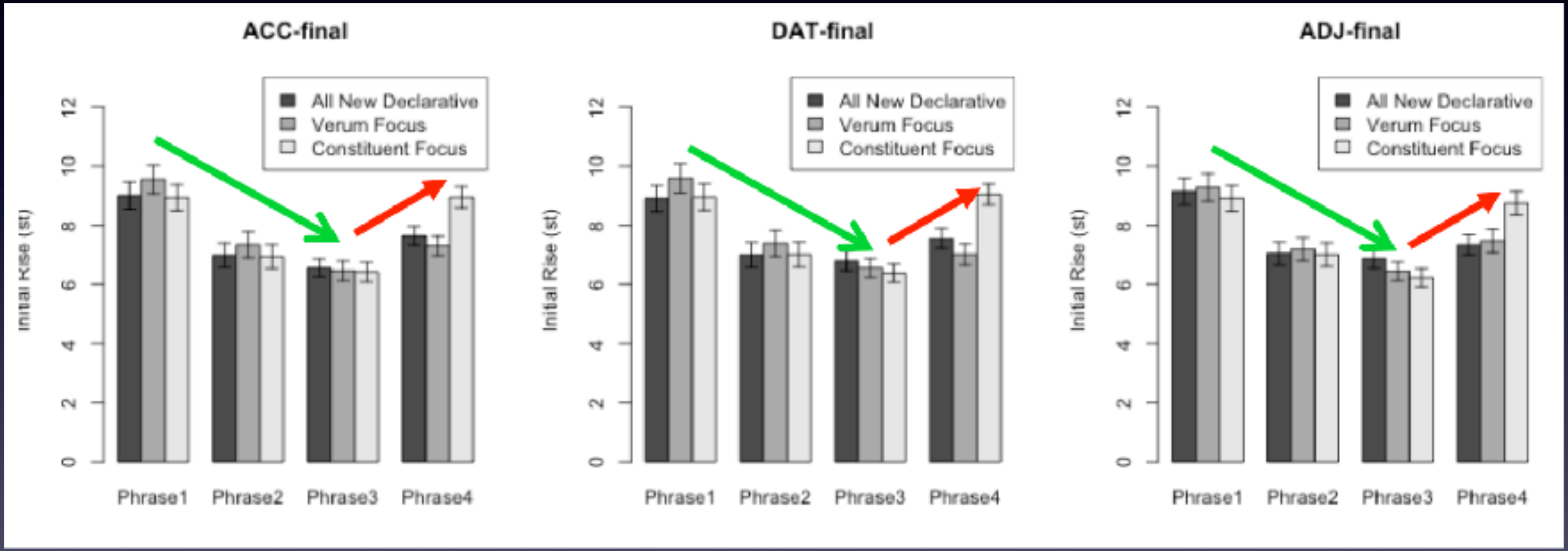
Commentary on Ishihara et al., "Non-focal prominence"

Their finding in short



- The pre-verbal elements show large initial rise, in spite of declination & downstep.
- This effect and the focus boost seem additive.
- Present even if the verb receives verum focus.

An analytical quibble

- It is probably better to calculate the difference between the pre-verbal element and the preceding element *within each sentence*.
- This method will “wash” away between-sentence noise; i.e. this is a very simple normalization method.

The main question that I want to address

- What is the nature of this prominence? (cf. their slides pp. 21-22).

- Which grammatical component is responsible for assigning this prominence/tone?

  - syntax?; I.e. the verb is assigning the prominence.

  - semantics?; I.e. the preverbal position bears some semantic significance.

  - phonological?; I.e. nothing to do with either syntax or semantics - something that I would like to explore.

What if it is phonological?

- Ishihara et al. characterize the locus of nuclear prominence as “pre-verbal”.
- Another way to characterize this position is “penultimate position” (second from last).
- Recall that this prominence appears regardless of the syntactic nature of the constituent under question.
- Syntax does not need to generate this prominence. Phonology can assign it.
- (The phonological hypothesis predicts that you don’t need a verb to observe this prominence. I don’t know if this prediction is borne out.)

This is a classic OT example

- In OT, NonFinality >> Rightmost gets us this result very easily.

	NonFinality	Rightmost
…E…E…E	*!	
…E…E…E		*
…E…E…E		**!

- A functional explanation: the prominence is demarcative, signaling the end of a sentence.

Some further evidence

	All New Declarative	**Verum Focus**	Constituent Focus
Higher peak on Noun	537	646	496
Higher peak on Particle	111	**2**	152

- This, again, is a class case of *CLASH (Prince 1983)
- Prediction: H-tone can dock on particles before unaccented verbs.

Questions arising from this interpretation

- Is it appropriate to call it “nuclear prominence”?
- Does syntax or semantics have anything to do with it? (cf. Truckenbordt 1995)
- What is the domain of this “prominence” or H-tone? Clause or whole sentence (cf. Kawahara & Shinya 2008)?

What if I am right?

- Yoshi was (is) entertaining the idea to derive scrambling from this prominence.
- Speakers do not want to place non-informative elements in this phonologically prominent position.
- Phonology affects syntax (see recent work by N. Richard, A. Anttila, J. Bresnan, S. Shih, K. Zuraw)?
- Phonology can precede syntax?

Something to think about

Pitch raising at the left edge of a branching phrase, a la Kubozono (1993)?

Something to think about 2

- The experiment shows that this penultimate prominence can “co-exist” with semantic focus, when they appear on the same element.

- Does this penultimate prominence survive, even given focus-driven F0 depression? (cf. Chris Tancredi’s question regarding Büring’s work, which predicts that the penultimate prominence would be “sucked” in to the focus prominence.)

Some thoughts about Expt 2

- The results of Experiment 2, which are a bit “fragile” (p.33), are not incompatible with the phonological interpretation of this prominence.
- One concern: “A recency hypothesis” (e.g. Gupta 2005). The results were obtained not because of its prominence but because of its late appearance, which tend to stay in memory.

- What if we use somewhat unusual sentences without the penultimate prominence? The recency hypothesis predicts the same results; the prominence hypothesis predicts that the reading facilitation effects go away.
- The “syntax/semantic” hypothesis may predict that this facilitation effects may remain because that position is prominent anyway, despite the absence of actual phonetic prominence (?).
- Another prediction of the recency hypothesis is more gradient. Antepenultimate nouns should be read faster than pre-antepenultimate nouns.